One-Day Deliverer

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One-Day Deliverer

by princesscas

Summary

Khaslana wakes up in Phainon’s body. Mydei decides it’s time for a day off.

Notes

greenbean had an idea so genius that i had to write it. i deviated slightly from the original concept but here it is !!

3.4 spoilers ahead!

See the end of the work for more notes

Khaslana knows something's wrong when he wakes in a bed. He hasn't slept in a bed in—well, he doesn't know how long. A long-ass time. Maybe centuries. If he sleeps, it's in the Aedes Elysiae of his dreams, and that's more like death than true sleep. But here he is, in bed, with the light of the dawn device gently weaving through the curtains.

Okhema. He's in Okhema.

Khaslana's chest feels tight. He takes a deep breath and throws off the duvet.

Then someone catches his wrist.

"Phainon," a familiar voice mumbles, tugging him back without much force. "It's not even the entry hour yet. Come back to bed."

Khaslana freezes. Slowly, he turns back. Lying there, with his eyes still closed, is Mydei. His Mydeimos. His Mydeimos, who has died thirty-three million deaths by his hand, who should look upon him with nothing but hatred.

Whose name for him hasn't changed, not once, in thirty-three million iterations.

Until now.

"Phainon," he says again, tugging harder. This time his eyes scrunch up like he's going to open them.

"…Coming," Khaslana rasps. His voice sounds different. Not so haggard anymore. And his hands feel stronger, his grip not yet scarred by the cut of destruction.

Mydei hums in approval. He drags Khaslana's arm over him, resting in the divot of his waist. Khaslana lies there, rigid, pressed against his back. Habitually, he glances down, looking for that spot beneath his heart, where the final blow will inevitably be dealt. His hand twitches.

"Relax," Mydei murmurs, tapping his fingers rhythmically against the back of Khaslana's hand. "It's just me. You're alright."

Khaslana exhales slowly. A dream, he tells himself. This must be a dream, albeit a crueler one than usual. He tries to let his tense shoulders melt into the bed.

"There you go," Mydei murmurs, his voice already hazy with sleep again. His grip slackens on Khaslana's hand. Then he's asleep, his breath even and his expression utterly relaxed.

Khaslana stares at the dawn device's light filtering through the curtains. He used to think it was too harsh; now it only feels beautiful. He sighs. His breath comes easier than before. Something's different in his chest, he thinks. Something big. Something important.

And then it clicks.

The coreflames. *The coreflames.*

They're all gone. His chest is empty.

He isn't Khaslana at all. He's *Phainon.* He's this cycle's Phainon, who has yet to take on any of the burden. Whose—and here Khaslana's throat tightens—whose Cyrene he had killed with his own hands.

Khaslana feels sick to his stomach. His real body has burned away to ash, crumbling away with every step he takes, and it no longer remembers how to mimic that sensation. But in Phainon's body, he feels the guilt like a stab wound.

Mydei exhales gently in his sleep. As his chest falls, his hand brushes Khaslana's again.

Quietly, Khaslana slips their fingers together. He lays there in silence and feels, for the first time, peace.

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He must fall back asleep, because he wakes up again to Mydei standing in front of him holding out a bowl of porridge with a jam swirl, a plate of sliced apricots, and a tall glass of water with three ice cubes, exactly how he likes it.

Khaslana blinks the sleep from his eyes. "What's this for? Is it poisoned?"

Mydei raises one eyebrow. "Poison?" he scoffs, setting down the meal on the bedside table. "Fool. I don't need poison. I'm going to defeat you on my own merit."

"Of course," Khaslana says quietly, trying not to think about the countless times Mydei has tried and failed to do just that.

Mydei pushes the water glass closer to him on the table. "Drink it. No one else can defeat you until I get my chance. I won't let dehydration take my victory from me, either."

"I'm not going to die of thirst," Khaslana grumbles, but halfway through the words, he realizes how dry his mouth feels. Begrudgingly, he reaches for the water glass.

Mydei's eyes crinkle when he smiles.

Khaslana can't look away. He tips the glass so far against his mouth that he spills water down his shirt and nearly chokes.

Mydei laughs at him. "Idiot." He reaches out and strips the shirt right off him, like it's nothing. Then he crosses the room, over to the wardrobe. "What do you want to wear today?"

Khaslana blinks. He sets the water back down. "I don't know," he says, his voice thick. "Whatever I usually wear. The Deliverer outfit, right?"

Mydei looks at him oddly out of the corner of his eye. He pulls the black undershirt out of the wardrobe and throws it at him without looking. Habitually, like it's ingrained in his muscle memory, Khaslana catches it in one hand. He puts it on and marvels at the fit of the fabric. It moves with his skin like it was made to be part of him.

He missed this, he realizes. He missed wearing Aglaea's clothes, and feeling so at home in them.

"Well?" says Mydei, crossing his arms against the wardrobe. "Is the porridge not good? I also have spelt bread with vinegar, and if you don't want apricots, I have plums instead."

Khaslana stares at him, bewildered. "You were never this nice to me before."

Mydei sighs. He uncrosses his arms. "You seem off today. I thought the least I could do was be nicer."

Khaslana freezes with his hand on the spoon. He knows. He must know, somehow, that he isn't Phainon. Or that he *is* Phainon. *Was* Phainon. Khaslana can't quite remember what he was before everything happened. He hopes he was someone like this Phainon. He hopes he was someone worthy of Mydei's kindness.

"See," says Mydei, raising one eyebrow. "This is what I'm talking about. Why am I doing all the talking? You'd usually be praising me to high hell and back by now."

Guiltily, Khaslana lifts the spoon to his mouth. The porridge is incredible; it's the perfect consistency, the perfect flavor, sweet and a little salty and gorgeously studded with dried fruit. "It's delicious," he says, inclining his head. "Thank you."

"Don't say it *now,"* he mutters. "You're making me feel bad."

Khaslana shovels in another three bites' worth on one spoon. He makes an exaggerated expression of ecstasy as he eats it.

Mydei's mouth quirks up at the corner.

Khaslana's heart swells with sudden, inexplicable joy. When he eats the next bite, it tastes even sweeter.

Eventually Mydei turns back around to the wardrobe and rummages around again. This time he pulls out the familiar pants, and then the white coat and the belt and shoulder straps. He throws them onto the bed without looking.

Khaslana sets down the now-empty bowl. He drinks the last of the water and then he stands up, taking the clothes. He goes into the other room and changes into them. It's bittersweet, he thinks. In his youth he took so many things for granted. He thought he would never get the chance to wear these again.

As he fastens the shoulder strap, Mydei knocks.

"Come in," Khaslana says.

Mydei opens the door. "I called Aglaea and canceled our meeting," he says without preamble. "She rescheduled a few days from now. Anyway, here." He holds out the Deliverer's blue cape. "It's too fragile to throw."

Khaslana's hands hesitate above the fabric. He feels like it'll be irreversibly tainted if he touches it.

Mydei tilts his head. "Skipping the cape today?"

Khaslana nods, relieved, and lets his hands fall away. "I'll still be recognizable without it, right?"

"Of course," Mydei says. He folds the cape up gently, tracing his hands across the fine fabric like it's the most precious thing he'll ever handle.

Khaslana swallows thickly. He wonders if Mydei is this gentle with his Phainon, too.

"So," says Khaslana, adjusting the waist belt one final time. "If we have the day off, how should we spend it?"

Mydei shrugs as he closes the wardrobe. "Spar?"

Khaslana's hands go ice cold. "No."

"Why not?"

A thousand of his deaths flash before Khaslana's eyes. A thousand spars, and a thousand victories. He exhales harshly. "I just don't want to."

Mydei's eyes soften. "We'll do something else," he says, placing a gentle hand on Khaslana's shoulder. Then he brushes past him, headed for the door. "I have an idea, actually."

The touch is gone just as fast as it arrived. Khaslana stares at his own shoulder for a few moments, wondering whether he imagined it.

"Well?" says Mydei, idly twirling his keys around one finger. He's leaning against the open door. "You coming?"

Khaslana snaps out of it. "Always," he says, and he steps forward into the light of the dawn device for the first time in decades.

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Mydei's idea of an outing is, apparently, taking him to the Twilight Courtyard.

"I'm not sick," Khaslana insists. With each step closer, the dread in his stomach grows. "Just because you think I'm feeling off today—"

"I know you aren't sick," Mydei mutters, grabbing his hand. "Stop being a baby and come with me."

Khaslana grits his teeth. He follows Mydei toward the reception desk.

…And then right past it, into the gently-lit grass field in the center.

Khaslana does a double take. It's a perfect, serene meadow, right in the middle of Okhema. He almost can't believe it. The glow of the dawn device is filtered through the vines draped over the open courtyard, making it softer, more welcoming.

"Hyacine said she just finished building the new Twilight Courtyard a couple months ago," Mydei says, looking over at him. "I haven't found time to visit until now."

"It's perfect," Khaslana breathes, delighted. It reminds him of the gentle flower fields beneath Aedes Elysiae, the fairy realm he'd escaped to as a child.

Mydei looks at him oddly. His brows furrow slightly, like he's trying to figure something out.

Khaslana frowns. "What?"

Mydei's eyes return to normal like nothing ever happened. "She should be here soon," he says, tapping something on his teleslate.

"She?" Khaslana asks, glancing around. "Who's coming?"

Mydei just grins. He finds a spot on the sloped grass and sits down, stretching out his legs.

"Fine, be like that," Khaslana huffs, looking down at him. The grass here is nice—green, and clearly cared for, but not damp. Perfect for sitting. He finds a good spot and sits down, turning around to face the entrance.

"Hi," says someone right in front of him.

Khaslana yelps.

Hyacine giggles. "You always fall for that! Who knew the great hero of Okhema would be scared by a tiny doctor?"

She plunks herself down right next to Khaslana, not even bothering to smooth out her dress. Khaslana's heart swells with simultaneous affection and terror. She's so professional, and yet so childish. Hyacine must be the strangest priestess that Okhema has ever known.

"You aren't tiny," Mydei says from his other side. "He's just ridiculously tall."

"You two are the same height!"

Mydei fakes an arrogant shrug, doing something ridiculous with his eyebrows. "But I wear it better."

Hyacine shakes her head and laughs. She leans closer to Khaslana on the grass.

"Don't," Khaslana blurts, his hand shooting out to stop her.

Hyacine looks at him, confused.

“It’s just—there was an insect on the grass,” he lies, trying to shake off the panic. “It’s gone now. Don’t worry.”

Hyacine doesn’t look convinced. “You don’t look very well. Your eyes show signs of extreme stress…”

“I’m fine,” Khaslana insists, his voice weak.

Hyacine reaches out with one hand. Khaslana shuts his eyes tightly. She’s always been so good, so pure of heart, and he’s always been so—so—and if she touches him, he’s sure he’ll ruin her forever.

But Hyacine’s hand makes contact with his forehead, and nothing happens.

“Hm,” says Hyacine. “You don’t have a fever… Any other symptoms?”

Khaslana opens his eyes slowly. Ludicrously, he half-expects Hyacine to have burnt her holy hands on him. But she looks entirely unaffected.

“…Yes,” he answers, stronger this time. “I’m alright. It’s just been a long few days.”

Hyacine smiles gently, her eyes sympathetic.

“Long few years,” Khaslana admits, his voice raspy. “Long few decades.”

Hyacine sighs, still smiling. “I know,” she says quietly. She lays her head down on the grass. “It’s been a long few decades for all of us, hasn’t it?”

Khaslana lowers himself down between her and Mydei. They’ve left a space just big enough for him, so that his hair spills into both of theirs. It’s sort of beautiful, the pink and white and blond all mixed together. He looks up at the dappled sky.

“It’s a wonderful place,” he says at last. “I’d love to come back someday.”

“I think so too,” she says. “It’s not the same as the Courtyard of old, but sometimes the past can’t be replaced.”

Khaslana sighs through his nose. “I know. What’s gone is gone.”

“But,” says Hyacine quietly, “we’ve built something beautiful nonetheless.”

Next to him, Mydei hums softly. He’s not quite smiling, but his face is soft, like he’s at peace.

With his last vestiges of bravery, Khaslana reaches out for Hyacine’s hand.

Hyacine takes it. She holds loosely onto his right hand, drumming her fingers to Mydei’s song. Khaslana’s chest swells. Although he doesn’t know the melody, his heart sings along.

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The water is warm.

Khaslana should have known that. The water is always warm in his memories. But those memories are flawed. They've been filtered through so many torturous iterations of the same scene that they've become larger than life. The bathhouse of Khaslana's memories is thirty million bathhouses, really. Thirty million baths, and only the most perfect one remains. Surely the real thing doesn't stack up.

And yet when he steps into the bath, the water is warm.

Slowly, Khaslana sinks deeper into the water. His shoulders are like iron; he's held them steady for so long that they barely remember how to relax.

But these aren't *his* shoulders, he remembers abruptly. These are Phainon's shoulders. Phainon, the Deliverer, who has yet to bear the weight of the world. Who should, in theory, be optimistic and easygoing. And yet his shoulders are just as tense as Khaslana's are.

Khaslana almost pities him.

"I haven't taken a rest day in a while, have I?" he says, looking over at Mydei for approval.

Mydei props his chin in his hand, elbow on the edge of the bath. "You never do," he says quietly, looking Khaslana in the eyes. "I wish you would, sometimes."

Khaslana looks back at him. His heart stings with something he can't quite name. He opens his mouth.

"A well-rested rival is better competition," Mydei says loudly, apropos of nothing. "I can't keep winning, Deliverer. At least give yourself a fighting chance."

Khaslana raises his eyebrows. He could have sworn Mydei was going to say something else, with that soft voice and those tender eyes and—

"Ah. This is what you postponed my meeting for? Your usual tomfoolery?"

Khaslana's spine goes rigid.

"Aw, give Snowy and Dei a break! They're just trying to have fun, Agy."

Tribbie. It's Aglaea and Tribbie. Khaslana feels lightheaded.

"Lady Aglaea," says Mydei, turning his head towards them. "Would you care to join us?"

Slowly, Khaslana turns around, expecting the worst. Surely Aglaea knows what he's done—what he's going to do—what he *has* to do. And even if she doesn't, surely Tribbie, who spent her days singing him to sleep when he was haunted with nightmares, can see it in his eyes.

But Aglaea and Tribbie stand there in their matching white bathing dresses, just the same as always.

"Of course," says Aglaea, bowing her head. She sinks into the water across from Khaslana. Her dress billows beneath the water, then slowly settles.

Tribbie smiles and sits down on the edge of the bath, dangling her legs above the water. She keeps her feet carefully hovering above the surface.

“Is it too hot for you?” Mydei asks, his voice soft. “I chose a colder bath than usual. You should be able to endure it, at least briefly.”

Tribbie looks pleasantly surprised. She dips her toe into the water, then beams. “Aw, thanks! We were scared that you had picked the boiling pool again, Dei… it would cook us through!”

Aglaea smiles. She takes the laurels from her hair, then combs it out gently with her fingers. “Teacher, will you help me? I’d like rosemary oil today.”

Tribbie beams. She reaches for a vial of oil and begins running her small hands through Aglaea’s hair, carefully separating each strand.

Khaslana watches them in silence. His memory is imperfect; mostly when he thinks of them, he remembers their deaths, their deaths, their deaths. He tries his best to commit their smiles to memory. To remember the gentleness with which they speak to one another, and the ease in their postures.

Slowly, Aglaea blinks open her eyes. “I wasn’t being serious earlier,” she says, looking at Khaslana with a knowing glint in her eyes. “You two have more than earned a few days of rest.”

“Especially you, Snowy,” Tribbie pipes up, leaning in from around Aglaea’s head. She splashes her feet in Khaslana’s direction. “You look so tired! You’ve earned a little break. Do you want us to do yours afterwards?”

Khaslana blinks. He touches his hair with one hand. “Is it dirty?”

“We just thought you might like it.”

Khaslana hesitates. He shouldn’t let Tribbie touch him. He *shouldn’t.* He’s not their Phainon, not really. But isn’t she saying these things to him? Isn’t she asking to do this for him, either way?

“It’s okay, Snowy! We’ll be extra careful not to pull your hair!”

Something in Khaslana’s chest pulls tight. Suddenly he can’t find the words. He just nods.

When Tribbie is done with Aglaea’s hair, she brings the same oil over to him and gently rinses his hair. Her hands are small and nimble, and as promised, her touch is careful. She doesn’t pull his hair or scratch his scalp. And yet Khaslana freezes up when her hands make contact with him.

“Snowy…” Carefully, Tribbie places both hands on his shoulders. “You can feel both of our hands, right?”

Khaslana jerks his head into a nod.

“You know where our hands are. They won’t surprise you. They won’t attack you.”

Khaslana shuts his eyes tight. The corners of his eyes feel wet. Maybe it’s the steam from the bath. He nods again.

This time, when Tribbie lifts her hands into his hair, she starts singing, so softly that the notes almost break before they reach his ears.

Khaslana inhales sharply. It’s the same song he always hears in his dreams. The sweet song to ward off nightmares. The song that drove away the evils that haunted him, before he learned to drive them away by himself. “Where is—where is that from?”

Tribbie lets the note trail off into a laugh. “Silly Snowy,” she says fondly. “It’s the same song we always sing to you. Our mama’s tune to keep us safe.”

“I remember it,” he says brokenly. “I remember it.”

He doesn’t know what else to say. But it feels important, somehow, that Tribbie—this Tribbie, who he didn’t grow up with, who has never known him—still knows the song that drives away his fears.

“Then it’s served its purpose,” Tribbie says, running her hands through his hair one last time. Then, quieter, “Mama would be proud that you like it.”

“She would be proud of you, too, for remembering it after all these years.”

Tribbie rinses off her hands in the water. “It’s not easy,” she admits. “But we remember the things we love.”

Khaslana closes his eyes. He remembers all of them, even after so long. He remembers thirty-three million versions of his companions, because he loves them all. Loves them with everything in his broken chest. “Yes,” he says. “We do.”

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In the evening they go to the Grove of Epiphany.

“I’m pretty sure there aren’t any restaurants here,” Khaslana says, yet again, as they continue to trek out of town. “Aren’t we heading out for dinner?”

“Yes,” says Mydei, and then he does not elaborate at all.

Khaslana sighs. Mydei’s been mysterious all day, but at least he doesn’t ask questions. That’s one of his finest qualities—if he trusts someone, he trusts them without reservation, without hesitation. Khaslana figures the least he can do is return the favor. So he keeps quiet and follows Mydei through the university doors.

Only to be nearly run over by—

“Heyyy,” says Cipher brightly, still spinning in circles around the room. “About time you two got here! Any later, and my tail woulda fallen off from how hard I’ve been chasing it!”

“I think,” says Anaxa faintly from over her shoulder, “your *tail* is the least of our concerns.”

Cipher plunks him back down on the ground and dusts off her hands. “There ya go, prof!” she says, turning him around by his shoulders. “I even dragged you down from your office! You still wanna pass up the opportunity to make the Crown Prince of Castrum Kremnos cook your dinner?”

Khaslana turns around, wide-eyed. *“You’re* cooking?”

Mydei shifts on his feet. “Don’t get used to it,” he mutters, turning away. “I thought we could have dinner with the professor and Castorice. But he never leaves the Grove, so.”

“It isn’t by choice,” Anaxa says, glaring at him. “If Aglaea had her way, I’d be locked up in here like a princess in a tower. Excuse me for a moment. I feel a bit ill.”

“You’re *fine,”* Cipher says, waving a hand carelessly. “So I spun you around a little! What-e-ver. It builds appetite!”

Anaxa sighs heavily. He readjusts his jacket, smoothing out the creases from Cipher’s grip. “Mydeimos,” he says, nodding. “And… you.”

Khaslana’s feet freeze in place. Anaxa, of all people, would be able to see through deception. Anaxa, who taught him everything he knows. Anaxa, who comes so close to uncovering the truth in every single cycle.

“No more property damage,” Anaxa says drily, giving him the faintest hint of a smile. “I remember that physics lecture, Phainon.”

Khaslana nearly weeps in relief. “Of course not,” he says. “I promise.”

“Princess Homebody’s in the kitchen downstairs,” Cipher says, already walking on ahead with her hands behind her head. “C’mon! Let’s not keep Her Royal Highness waiting.”

“I’m the royal highness here,” Mydei mutters, but he follows her into the Grove’s culinary classrooms regardless.

Castorice is setting out napkins on one of the tables. When they enter, she waves and takes the seat at the head of the table. She’s set all the other places further away, so she can sit at the table with them but remain far enough away to ensure their safety.

Khaslana smiles, just a little. She’s always been considerate like that. He takes the seat closest to her.

“Hey, princess,” Cipher sings as she sits down. She props her head in her chin, grinning at Castorice across the table. “Come here often?”

Castorice blinks. “Yes,” she says, tilting her head. “I studied here. I still come here frequently to help Professor Anaxa with research.”

“Anaxagoras,” says Anaxa under his breath.

“To be honest, I didn’t think you'd join us,” Castorice says, smiling gently at him. “You don’t usually eat meals.”

“I detest ordinary food,” Anaxa scoffs, turning up his nose. “But I suppose the boy’s cooking isn’t so bad.”

From the counter to their left, Mydei rolls his eyes. He skewers a piece of zucchini with more force than necessary.

“Be nice to him,” Castorice says. “He’s only twenty-three.”

Mydei stabs another piece of zucchini with passion.

Cipher gasps dramatically. “Really? Little baby! When I was twenty-three, I was still doing honest work at the seamstress’s place!” She pauses briefly. “Well. *Semi-honest* work. Honest-ish. There may have been a teensy bit of jewel theft involved.”

Castorice gives her a look.

“An itty little bit!” Cipher says hurriedly, throwing up her hands. “Miniscule, even!”

“There’s a saying,” says Anaxa pointedly, “about leopards and spots. And the inability to change.”

Cipher’s mouth scrunches up. She slouches back in her chair, pouting.

“I didn’t expect to see you here, Lord Phainon,” says Castorice encouragingly, clearly trying to change the subject. “Do you and Lord Mydei have business here? Do you need help researching something?”

Khaslana shakes his head. “Mydei just thought we should visit, so here we are.”

At the head of the table, Castorice smiles. “Good,” she says, more gently than usual. “I’m glad.”

“What?” Khaslana says, raising his eyebrows at her. “What did I do?”

“Nothing,” she says hurriedly. Then, more convincingly, “I’m just… glad you’re alright. I had heard you weren’t feeling well today. I was expecting the worst.”

Khaslana wonders who told her. Maybe Hyacine; maybe Aglaea; maybe Mydei himself, just as a warning. “I’m alright now,” he says quietly, and only after saying it does he realize it’s the truth. “I just… missed you all, I guess.”

The air around her sweetens with the gentle, lulling scent of flowers. “I’m glad you came to visit. The Grove isn’t the same without your spirit.”

Khaslana swallows the sudden lump in his throat. “I don’t know if I still have it,” he says, faintly nervous. “That spirit, I mean.”

Anaxa looks at him like he’s said the sky is real. “Of course you do,” he scoffs, rolling his one good eye. “If it ever goes away, I’ll start praying to Kephale. I can still see it in your eyes, you know.”

Khaslana blinks. “My eyes?”

“I can tell you still dream of being a hero.”

Khaslana stares at him. “I don’t think I count anymore,” he says, a little desperately. “I’ve—I’ve made so many mistakes. I’m not the person I once was.”

Anaxa just shrugs. “Leopards, spots,” he says. “People don’t change.”

For just a second, he looks at Khaslana like he sees right through him. Khaslana freezes under his gaze. People don’t change, he had said. Khaslana doesn’t know if that’s true. He thinks he’s changed much over all these cycles. He’s changed a thousand times over, and rarely for the better.

“Guess you were always a stubborn, whiny bastard, then,” Cipher says to Anaxa, grinning at him with all her teeth.

Anaxa smiles wryly. “And I suppose you always had a big heart and bigger pockets?”

For a moment it looks like they’re going to fight. But then Cipher laughs at him, and he laughs back, and they almost look like old friends, with their eyes crinkled in laughter and their faces worn by the years.

Khaslana is so busy committing their joy to memory that he doesn’t even notice Mydei approaching.

“Food,” Mydei announces, plunking down two dishes. “Left one’s for you, Cipher. Steamed sea bream with asparagus. Right one is Castorice. It’s the same fish cut, but pan-fried with tomato and onion.”

Cipher looks at the tomatoes and wrinkles her nose. She slides the plate across the table to Castorice like a discus.

“Thank you, Lord Mydei,” Castorice says, reaching out for her fish. “It looks wonderful.”

“And—” This time Mydei brings over a bowl. “—I know you have trouble eating, professor. So you have bone broth soup with rice and wilted spinach. It should be easy to digest.”

Anaxa takes the bowl from him with a nod. “It sounds wonderful, Mydeimos.”

Though he tries to hide it, Mydei's mouth quirks up at the corner at the praise. At last he returns with the final two dishes, balanced precariously in his arms.

"Ooh," says Cipher, grinning around her fork. "What nasty concoction has the legend crafted this time?"

Khaslana looks at her, alarmed.

"It isn't bad," Mydei mutters, his face flushed pink. "I only make bad food when I'm mad at him. It's like putting him in the doghouse."

"You're never not mad at him," Cipher points out.

Mydei just sighs. He sets down both plates. They're exactly identical—two beautiful pieces of braised sea bream, smothered in spiced sauce, accompanied with thick slices of rye bread and a pile of corn salad with onions and sauteed peppers. On the side is a tiny slice of grilled cornbread with a thin strawberry slice on top.

"It's perfect," Khaslana says weakly. He can't remember the last time he ate before today. Mydei's feast smells like the finest thing the world has to offer. "Thank you."

"Just eat it," Mydei mutters, his face going even darker with embarrassment.

Maybe Anaxa was right, Khaslana thinks, as he takes his first bite. Maybe people don't change. Because he's loved these people for his whole life. All of his lives. That hasn't changed, not once, and it won't ever change, not in another thirty-three million cycles.

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That night Mydei takes him back home and they lie down to sleep. Khaslana waits patiently for Mydei to leave. He doesn't. Instead he lies next to him again, close enough to feel his warmth.

Khaslana finally bites the bullet and turns to him.

"Mydeimos," he says quietly. "Are we lovers?"

Mydei looks at him carefully. "…You aren't my lover," he says at last.

Khaslana turns away from him and looks up at the ceiling. He sighs out a breath.

"Phainon is my lover. And I know you aren't him."

Khaslana stares at the ceiling, wide-eyed, not daring to look in his direction.

Mydei's hand finds Khaslana's underneath the covers. He doesn't intertwine their fingers. He just lets their hands rest next to each other, pinkies touching. "I knew you weren't him," he says. "Phainon always says, *Good morning, gorgeous,* when I wake him up. Phainon has already been to the new Twilight Courtyard. Phainon knows he's never taken a rest day in his life. And Phainon doesn't look at me like I'm already gone."

“I’m sorry, Mydeimos,” he whispers. “I don’t mean to. It’s just—”

“I know,” Mydei says softly. “I know, Deliverer.”

Khaslana swallows thickly. This time, when Mydei draws close again, Khaslana lets him. He tucks himself under Khaslana’s arm, the same way he was when they awoke. They sink into the bed, warm and tangled together.

Mydei’s name for him really hasn’t changed, he thinks, just before he falls asleep. In the end he’s still the Deliverer. In the end Mydei still believes in him. Still thinks, above all, that he can one day become the hero he’s always sought to become.

His chest is warm, and his heart is full. Khaslana closes his eyes.

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“Good morning, gorgeous,” says Phainon the next morning, hovering above Mydei’s face. He leans down for a kiss before Mydei can even respond.

Mydei smiles up at him. He grins into the kiss, pulling him down by his neck.

Phainon actually pulls away and stares at him. “What’s gotten into you? You’re supposed to shove me off and tell me to go back to sleep.”

“Mm,” says Mydei. “I missed you.”

Phainon’s eyes soften with surprise.

“Let’s have a day off,” Mydei says, kissing his nose briefly. “We’ll sleep in together, and then we can go to the market and buy breakfast and groceries. You can look at antiques. We’ll have a spar and then bathe together. And then you can take me out for dinner at the new restaurant by the Dawncloud entrance.”

Phainon’s breath catches in his chest. “Alright,” he says, smiling down at him. “That sounds wonderful, Mydei. Let’s do it.”

Mydei loops closer to him. Then, quietly, so quietly that Phainon nearly misses it, “I love you.”

Phainon hums into his hair. “What was that?”

“Nothing,” Mydei mutters into his shoulder. “Shut up and go back to bed.”

Phainon smiles. He closes his eyes again, with his Mydeimos wrapped up safely in his arms, and for the first time in so many years, he rests.

End Notes

i didn’t find time to mention it but our phainon spent the whole day dreaming of aedes elysiae :) he was in khaslana’s inner world! anyway he had a lovely day

please drop a comment / kudos if you enjoyed! 3.4 knocked me flat on my ass but at least there was a ridiculous amount of phaidei in there!! it isn’t a phainon update without 6 mydei appearances, at least 3 of which mention his body. it’s indestructible btw did you know. he tested it himself

find me on tumblr (princesscas-ao3)!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!